FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

Cynics might scoff and say we would all be happy if only we knew how to define happiness. Scientists might reduce it to chains of chemicals in the brain. Lovers will find it in their amorous feelings. Religions might say the world itself is made up of sadness and prescribe a protocol for elevating the spirit. But what are the secrets of happiness—and how do we attain it?

This special issue explores the various dimensions of this elusive quality, emotion or feeling to unravel the mystery that surrounds it both at the conceptual level and the practical. It is not easy to make such a division in reality—in spirituality, for instance, theory *is* practice. We bring you in this issue the wisdom of a gamut of gurus who delve into spiritual truths relating to happiness, as they have known and divined them.

An amazing congruence of views strikes us as we read their words. Most insist happiness is an internally generated state, immune to the mercurial nature of the world. Swami Gaur Gopal Das, for one, says: "When your state of mind is negative, even the best of things don't give happiness. When the state of mind is right, even the simplest thing can bring joy. The mind can turn heaven into hell or hell into heaven." Match that with what Sister B.K. Shivani says: "When my mind's graph does not fluctuate, then I have been happy throughout the day...the truth is, happiness is our nature, our way of being." Or with what Mata Amritanandamayi offers in her first gesture: "Happiness is not in objects. It's within us. It is the very purpose of life." Yoga guru Baba Ramdev adds to that construct when he says, "You don't earn happiness. You live happy when your existence makes a positive impact on someone else's life." In Ajmer Sharif Dargah, Haji Syed Salman Chishty too insists on true happiness being "the goal of all goals". All distances—physical, cultural, religious—disappear on the spiritual path.



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To seek to attain that state is not only the work of rishis but of every individual. So alongside the gurus, we interviewed a wide cross-section of prominent individuals about their own pacts with happiness. From dancer Mallika Sarabhai to Union minister Anupriya Patel, from Paralympian Bhavina Patel and Olympic champ Neeraj Chopra to YouTuber CarryMinati to son-of-the-soil farm activist Rakesh Tikait, from chef Suvir Saran to actress Sunny Leone, from business honchos like Pankaj R. Patel of Zydus to politician Mahua Moitra, we cover entire rainbows of life secrets. Some of them sound almost in sync with the gurus. BYJU'S co-founder Divya Gokulnath seems to read from that same inner text when she says: "My happiness does not depend on external validation but rather comes from within myself." But the range also takes in the colours of the everyday. "Gratification for me comes when people recognise, praise and love my work," says actress Bhumi Pednekar. TV, theatre and film actress Shefali Shah plumps for "being with my loved ones, all of us safe, healthy and happy. There's food, banter, laughter, music, dance...or just doing nothing at all".

Nature and a sense of bodily unity with physical space come in as strong themes. Union minister Mansukh Mandaviya values the joy of work and changing lives, but also cycling and visiting his native village, its farms and streets. Architect Nilanjan Bhowal votes for "the smell of the wet earth". Two Lok Sabha MPs from Bengal touch on the pleasures of food—another common reservoir of happy memories. Mahua Moitra, besides "kind, loving spaces with no negative energy", mentions "*adrak chai*, toast and *bhujia*". And Mimi Chakraborty, while affirming for herself being the reason for someone else's smile, is not chary of mentioning "a large slice of pizza".

We also feature 15 personages and institutions from the realm of *doing*—those who bring happiness to others and to themselves through interventions in the social sphere. Take only two of them. Born a male in Kondagaon district of Chhattisgarh, transgender Vidya Rajput suffered years of abuse before helping create the Transgender Welfare Board, ensuring access to subsidised foodgrains to those of the third gender. Nutrition was also the kernel element in Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla's efforts: his native Kota had been rocked by a high incidence of infant deaths in 2019. His Suposhit Maa Abhiyan aims to strike at the root of that.

To put the whole question of happiness in perspective, the United Nations brings out an annual World Happiness Report. In successive editions of this report, India has consistently been in the bottom percentile of 146 nations. In 2022, we marginally improved going from rank 139 to 136, but still only Afghanistan under the Taliban came off worse than India among all South Asian nations. Nepal (84) was best, followed by Bangladesh (94) and Pakistan (121), and even strife-torn Sri Lanka (127) managed better.

Indians, as we all know, can be happy even under the most adverse conditions. But perhaps we do need to engage seriously with that definition. While determining the ranking of nations, the poll agency, besides seeking out socio-economic parameters, asks respondents whether their life "is in balance", they "feel peace", and focus on "caring for others or self". That saw Scandinavian countries like Finland, Denmark, Iceland and Sweden occupy the top slots. Of course, material abundance and wall-to-wall social welfare helps them get there. But in 2018, an internal survey by the Nordic countries also found an "epidemic of mental illness and loneliness". High suicide rates have often been talked about too—Sweden topped the developed world in the 1960s and, in the middle of the past decade, it was the third major cause of deaths in the age-group 16-24 in Finland, the No. 1 Happy country. So, while we could improve the socio-economic conditions of our citizens, there is much wisdom, too, in the paths prescribed by the gurus and others we feature in this issue.

INDIA TODAY, as always, stays committed to this theme: in our next endeavour along with our partners RPG Enterprises in this happiness quest, we plan to determine the Happiest Workplaces in India through a survey and award the winners.

Before and beyond, wishing all of you success in finding your secret to happiness.

(Aroon Purie)